



EL CASTILLO

The pyramid rises to a height of 79 ft (24 m). At the top is a carving of Kukulcán, the plumed serpent—an important Mesoamerican deity.

Yaxchilán

Nestled deep in the rainforest, this impressive Maya site is famous for its structures, monuments, and spectacular relief carvings



N. Central
America

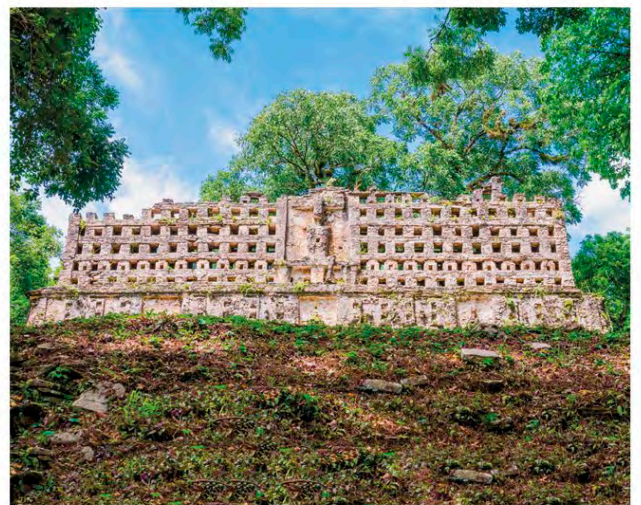
Bordered on three sides by the mighty River Usumacinta, deep in the rainforest of Mexico's Chiapas state—in the heart of what was the Maya's most densely populated region—the city of Yaxchilán commanded a strong defensive position. Many of the city's major temples were built in the hilltops above the river and may have served as astronomical observatories.

Maya art

The site flourished from around 681 CE under Lord Shield Jaguar II. It is notable for its sculptures—in particular, the spectacular carved stone lintels above the doorways, commissioned by various of the city's rulers, which often depict the bloodletting ceremonies, sacrifices, and torture that held sacred significance for the Maya. Several of the lintels are among the masterpieces of Maya art.

◀ STELA 35

This stela, c.600–900 CE, depicts Lady Eveningstar, a wife of Shield Jaguar the Great. She may have ruled Yaxchilán briefly, a decade after her husband's death.



△ THE KING PALACE

Structure 33 at Yaxchilán, built in the mid-8th century CE, is a magnificent example of Classic Maya architecture. Its roof-comb wall includes friezes, niches, and sculptural elements.

